Presentation Converter user guide

Presentation Converter turns **Keynote, PowerPoint, Google Slides, ODP and Canva decks into PDFs with a presenter-notes sidecar**. It comes as a CLI, a GUI and a Nextcloud app.

> **Status:** in development, tagged at v0.3.0. The screenshots here are real captures of the running app, made by its own screenshot script.

The problem it actually solves

A deck's slide count and its PDF's page count usually **disagree**, because every exporter silently drops hidden or skipped slides.

Convert a 4-slide deck whose third slide is hidden and you get a 3-page PDF, so a naive tool puts slide 3's notes on page 3, **and every note from there on is a page out**.

This tool reads the PDF back, reconciles the two, and records what it did:

```
"alignment": "adjusted"   // hidden slides accounted for; mapping is trustworthy
"alignment": "exact"      // counts agreed
"alignment": "mismatch"   // couldn't reconcile — notes emitted, but flagged as suspect
```

> **Check `alignment` on anything that matters.** A `mismatch` shows up in the CLI, in the GUI and in the sidecar's `warnings` rather than being wrong without telling anyone, but it's still written out, so nothing stops you using it.

Installing

Needs **Node.js 20+**.

```
git clone https://github.com/stoatworks-labs/presentation-converter.git
cd presentation-converter
npm install
npm run build
```

For PowerPoint and ODP files, install LibreOffice. On a Mac, PowerPoint or Keynote can stand in for it with PowerPoint decks; ODP needs LibreOffice.

Find out what your machine can actually do before you need it to:

```
node packages/cli/dist/index.js doctor
```

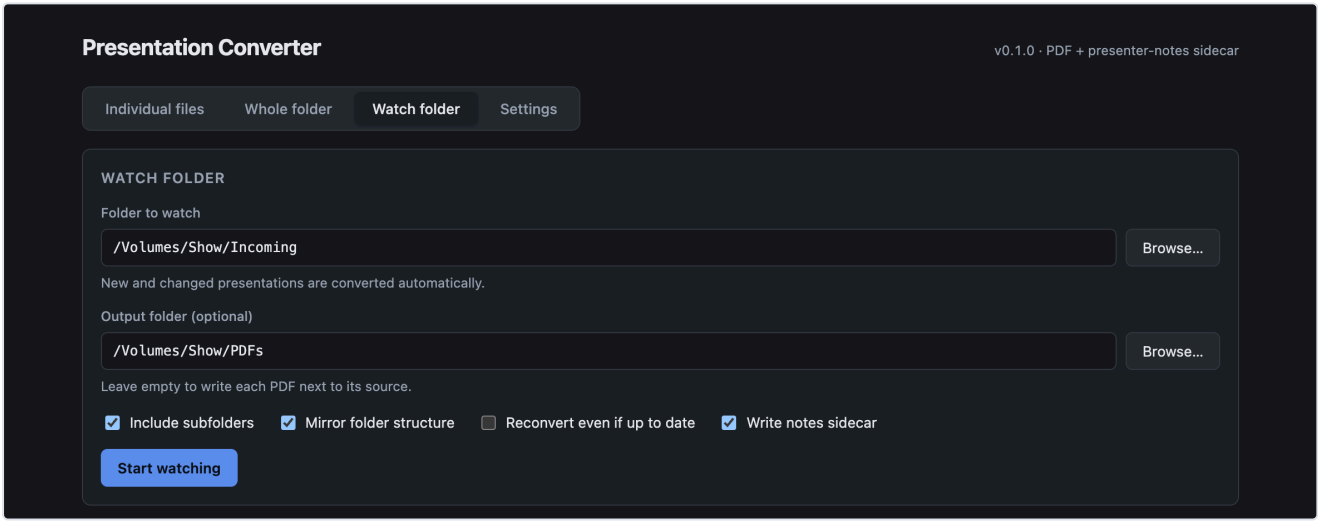
Converting

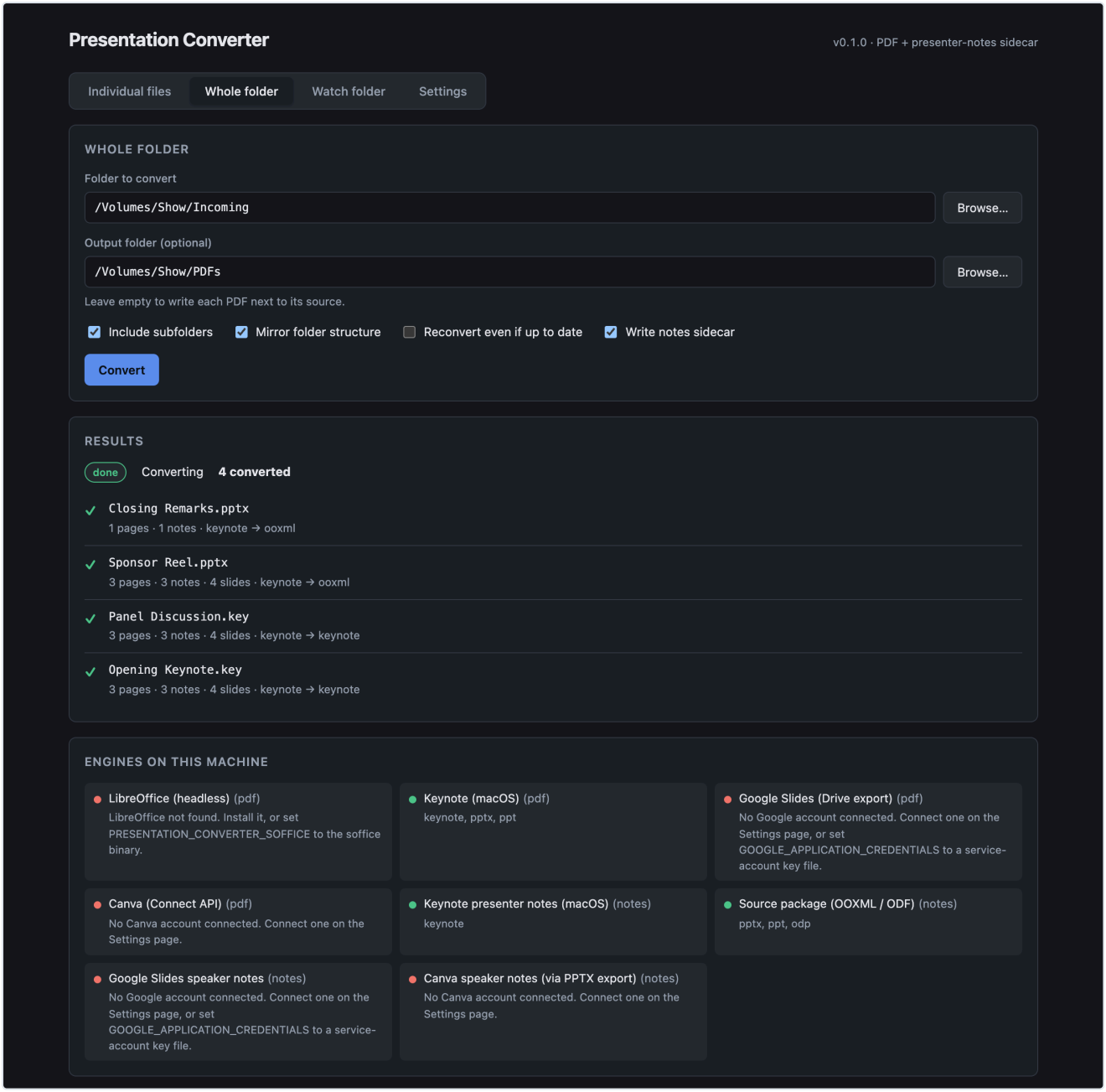
```
# some files
presentation-converter convert "Q3 Review.key" "Keynote Address.pptx"

# a whole tree
presentation-converter batch ~/Decks --out-dir ~/PDFs

# a folder, continuously
presentation-converter watch ~/Dropbox/Incoming --out-dir ~/PDFs

# the GUI and worker API, at http://127.0.0.1:4747
presentation-converter serve
```





Everything takes `--json` for scripting, and **exits non-zero if any file failed**.

Re-runs are incremental: a deck whose PDF and sidecar are already newer than it gets skipped, so a repeat batch over an unchanged folder takes milliseconds. Use `--force` to override that.

Options worth knowing

Flag	Effect
`--out-dir <dir>`	Write PDFs here instead of beside the source; the folder tree is mirrored
`--flat`	Don't mirror subfolders — everything lands in one directory
`--force`	Reconvert even when the output is already newer than the source
`--no-sidecar`	Write only the PDF
`--pdf-engine <id>`	Force `libreoffice`, `powerpoint`, `keynote`, `google-slides` or `canva`
`--exclude <text...>`	Skip any path containing this text
`--dry-run`	(batch) List what would be converted, then stop

What converts with what

> **I've kept notes extraction independent of PDF rendering on purpose.** For Office and ODF files the notes are read straight out of the source package's XML, so you get the author's text word for word whichever engine drew the PDF, and that part works **headless, with no application installed**.

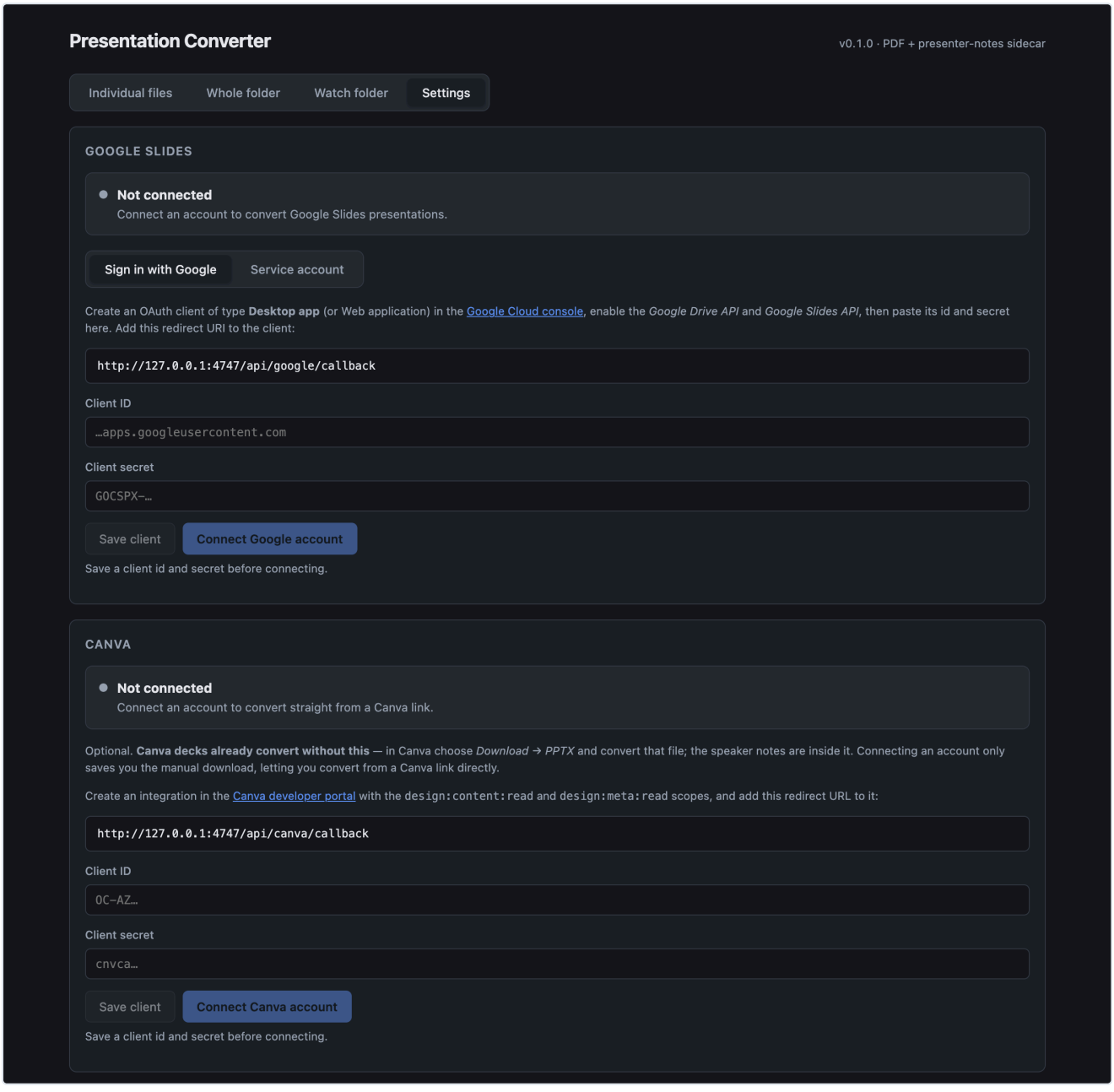
Format	PDF rendered by	Notes read from
`.key`	Keynote (**macOS only**)	Keynote
`.pptx`	LibreOffice, or PowerPoint, or Keynote on macOS	the `.pptx` package (OOXML)
`.ppt`	LibreOffice, or PowerPoint, or Keynote on macOS	promoted to `.pptx` by LibreOffice, then the package
`.odp`	LibreOffice	the `.odp` package (ODF)
Google Slides	Drive export	Slides API
Canva	PPTX export, rendered locally	the exported `.pptx` (OOXML)

Keynote can't run on Linux, so a Linux host needs a paired Mac for `.key` files. See nextcloud.md.

On a Mac with no LibreOffice, a PowerPoint deck goes to **PowerPoint** if it's installed, since it draws the deck in the author's own fonts, and to Keynote if not. Both are driven over AppleScript, so the first time, macOS asks whether whatever is running the converter (your terminal, say) may control them. A `.ppt` still needs LibreOffice for its notes; without it, convert with `--no-sidecar`.

> **Two Keynotes?** With both Keynote and Keynote Creator Studio installed, it drives **Creator Studio**. The older Keynote opens to a dialog telling you it's out of date and waits for a click that never comes, so it's left alone. `doctor` says which one it will use.

Connecting accounts



Credentials are stored in your user config directory with `0600` permissions, and the page shows the exact path. **Environment variables, when they're set, take precedence over anything saved here.**

Google Slides

Pass a share URL, a file id, or a `.gslides` shortcut:

```
presentation-converter convert "https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/FILE_ID/edit" -o
~/PDFs
```

Connect an account either in **Settings** (sign in, or paste a service-account key) or by environment variable, which is best for servers:

```
export GOOGLE_APPLICATION_CREDENTIALS=/path/to/service-account.json
```

Either route needs **both the Google Drive API and the Google Slides API** enabled on the project. Two limits that catch people out:

- **A service account can only see presentations shared with its email address.**
- **Drive refuses to export presentations over 10 MB.**

Canva

```
presentation-converter convert "https://www.canva.com/design/DAFxyz123/edit" -o ~/PDFs
```

Or with no setup at all: export from Canva with **Download → PPTX** and convert that file like any other PowerPoint deck. Canva puts the speaker notes in it.

> **The Canva engine exports PPTX, never PDF**, and renders that file locally. Canva's API has no notes field, so it has to fetch a PPTX anyway, and taking the pages from the same file halves the API cost and guarantees the notes and the pages describe the same version of the deck. **It does mean you need LibreOffice, PowerPoint or Keynote.**

See canva.md.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause
Notes are one slide out	Check `alignment` in the sidecar. A `mismatch` means it could not reconcile the counts.
Slide count ≠ page count	Normal — exporters drop hidden slides. That is what the reconciliation is for.
`.key` file won't convert	Keynote is macOS-only. A Linux host needs a paired Mac.
`.pptx` or `.odp` won't convert	LibreOffice isn't installed or isn't found (on a Mac, PowerPoint or Keynote covers `.pptx`). Run `doctor`.
PowerPoint: "has not let this process control PowerPoint"	Allow it in System Settings ▸ Privacy & Security ▸ Automation.
A Keynote or PowerPoint conversion times out	A dialog is open in the app, waiting for you. Answer it and run again.
Nothing happened on a re-run	Incremental skip — the outputs are newer than the source. Use `--force`.
Google: "file not found" with a service account	The deck has not been shared with the service account's email address.
Google: export fails on a big deck	Drive refuses presentations over 10 MB.
Canva converts but needs LibreOffice	By design — it exports PPTX and renders locally.
Saved credentials seem to be ignored	An environment variable is set, and it takes precedence.

See also

- sidecar-format.md: the notes sidecar, including the `alignment` field
- canva.md: the Canva engine and why it exports PPTX
- nextcloud.md: the Nextcloud app, and the paired-Mac arrangement for Keynote
- README: full option list and downloads